

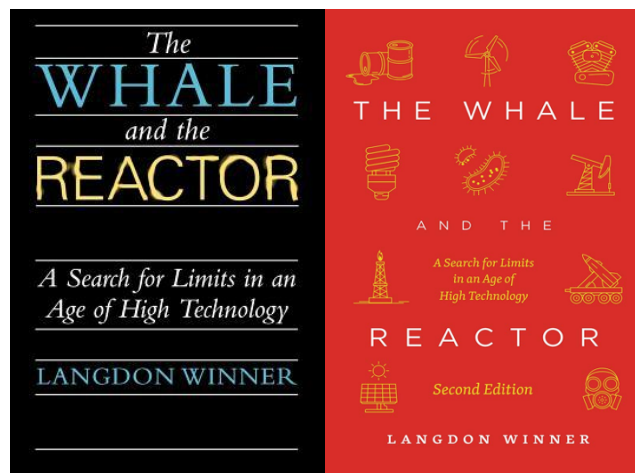
SOCIAL THEORY & DESIGN THINKING

(2410302)

Politics & Global Studies (PGS)

1st Semester 2025 (1/2025-26)
Tuesday: 1-4 p.m.
Building POL3, Room M08

Week 6: Design & Democracy's Group Exercise



Theories, Concepts, Analyses and Critiques

Task: Every group must do all SIX items/questions below.

Quiz#1 is approaching in two weeks. The clock is ticking. I would like to take this opportunity to ask you to start preparing for the Quiz#1 using the materials from this week's theme: Design & Democracy. Langdon Winner's *The Whale and the Reactor: A Search for Limits in an Age of High Technology* (1986/2020) is probably one of the best books on design/design thinking, and probably, one of the best scholarly books ever written on any subjects and disciplines! In designing this course, I consider using Winner's text as one of the core pieces for you to familiarize yourself with the philosophical and critical foundations of design and technology.

As I will distribute the digital copy of the Quiz#1 overview in class next Tuesday, I would like this week's exercise to create an initial awareness regarding what kinds of items/questions will likely appear before your eyes in the compute room when you

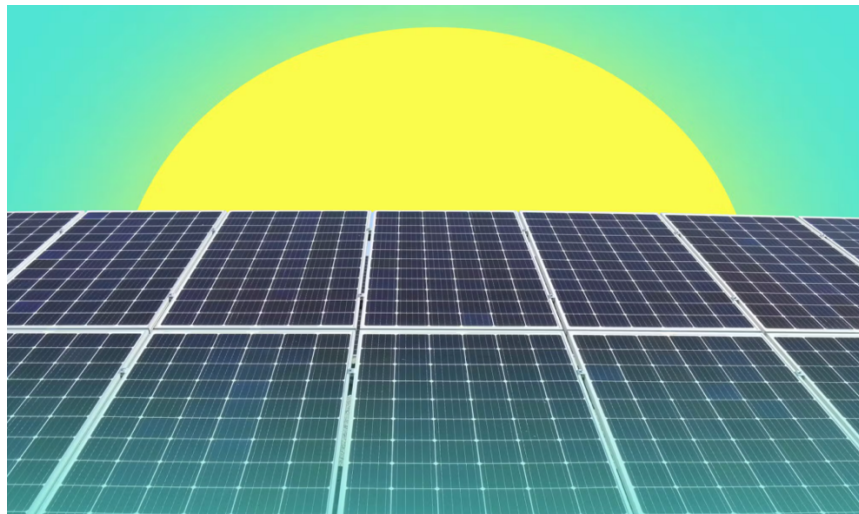
are ready to take the exam. The six items/questions below simulate the actual quiz items/questions. That's why I kindly ask you to attempt and accomplish all of them.

In addition, there will be some grading criteria for each item/question attempted in the Quiz#1 overview. Because the maximum points for each item/question is 5, you can only get a 4-point score by doing/answering correctly in your own words possibly with no mistakes. In order to score a 5, you must achieve somethings more, such as, giving a further application using the theories/concepts in the corresponding items/questions to analyze an example/case study of your own choosing, and/or criticizing the veracity of the theories/concepts themselves. Since there is a time and space limited concern, you should not think too much and definitely cannot do too much. Just show me that you can go beyond a mere good summary of your completion/answer to the item/question.

You should go back to this piece of assigned readings, if you have not done so. The SIX items/questions below are text-based.

Please do/answer the SIX items/questions in your own words in a clear and concise bullet points or short paragraphs that could be put on the Microsoft PowerPoint or any other presentation computer software's and mobile phone applications' pages. You completion of each item or answer to each question should be only 2 pages. Then, your further analysis and critique in each item/question should be only 2 more pages. In case you have some illustrations, you are allowed to have more than 4 pages (but no more than 6 pages) for each item/question.

The last remaining 3 groups in Round 1 of the Group Exercise will give a short, no more than 10 minutes presentation at the beginning of next week's session. Each of will present only 2 items/questions that are not similar to those of the other two groups. All 12 groups must submit their slides by uploading their PDF files into the designated folder(s) in Week 6's folder in the course's Google Drive. Many thanks for your cooperation.



- 1) As Winner writes, "it is reasonable to suppose that a society thoroughly committed to making artificial realities would have given a great deal of thought to the nature of that commitment" (p. 3).

Yet he says we haven't really begun "to examine critically the nature and significance of artificial aids to human activity" (p. 4). **Why not? (pp. 5-6, until " ... as regards their moral standing")**

- 2) The problem with the commonsense "neutrality" conception of technology is that "it disregards the many ways in which technologies provide structure for human activity." (p. 6).

Explain Winner's opposing claim that technical devices and systems create "distinctive worlds" (p. 8) or "forms of life" (p. 11).

- 3) One way in which “technical things have political qualities” (p.19) concerns technologies that exhibit a flexibility in how they are implemented: a flexibility which reveals a range of social consequences and thus the need for wide-spread participation and accountability in decision-making about the technology.

Explain this claim, using the examples of Robert Moses (pp. 22-23), the McCormick’s reapers and molding machines (pp. 24-25), and the mechanical tomato harvester (pp. 26-27).

- 4) Explain Winners’ second, stronger claim that at least some technological devices and systems are “inherently political” in that they appear to require, or at least strongly encourage, certain specific patterns of political structure, using the examples of business organizations (pp. 34-35) and plutonium production to fuel nuclear reactors (pp. 37-38).

X) A Surprised Item/Question. You may or may not do it. I salute you, if you do it.

In the second edition of *The Whale and the Reactor: A Search for Limits in an Age of High Technology* (2020), Winner has added Chapter 11: "Beyond Techno-Narcissism: Self and Other in the Digital Public Realm" (pp. 179-196). In Preface to the Second Edition (pp. vii-x), he says that:

"Stories taking note of 'political artifacts' or equivalent phenomena crop up now in discussions about the power of algorithms on Internet platforms; in debates about robotics, artificial intelligence, and the future of work; and in studies of the dangers that misinformation now poses for the most basic workings of democracy. At times, it seems my once bizarre heresy has finally become a weary truism" (p. vii).

If you have a chance to read this fascinating newly additional chapter, please reconstruct the main claims/arguments of it. What is really Winner's "once bizarre heresy ..." (p. vii)? What is his main concern about the "digital public realm"?

